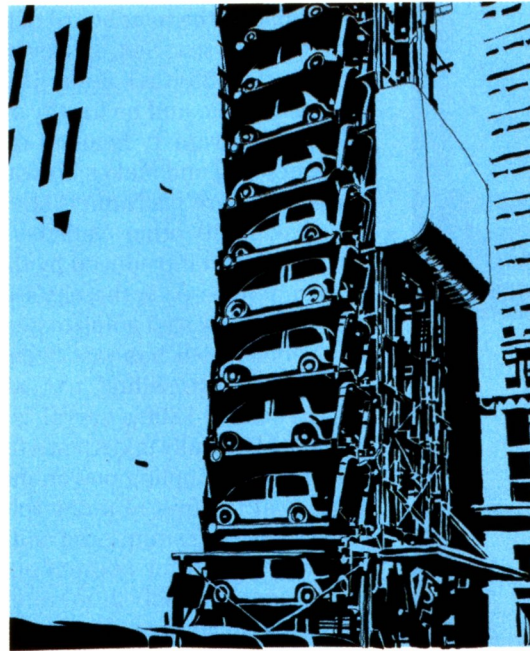


page he last looked at the night before.

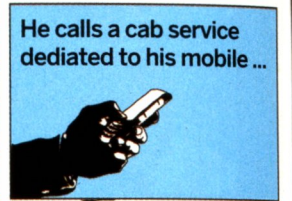
Bharat skips the treadmill since he is running late and switches to TV mode to catch up with the latest news before getting down to work. The Grave New World, as analysts have dubbed the events leading to 2020, is sending mixed signals. The decline of the US means a new world order, dominated by China, is still in the making. In India, on the corporate front, the Ambani brothers are still locked in litigation, having together spent more on legal fees than the net worth of the contracts they have been fighting each other for. Jet Airways and Kingfisher, facing financial ruin, have just announced a strategic merger, but there is still intense friction over whether the new no-frills entity should be called JetKing, KingJet or FisherPrice. Politically, Prime Minister Rahul Gandhi is still finding his feet, his wafer-thin majority forcing him to align with a resurgent Left. The political wheel has come full circle. He's not getting much help from mother Sonia, who has renounced active politics along with her former prime minister Manmohan Singh. The two are busy on the global lecture circuit delivering talks on successful partnership models and inclusive democracy.

At the UN, Bono, the secretary-general, has just named Balochistan as the 194th country to be recognised by the agency. Restive, mineral-rich Balochistan broke away from Pakistan earlier in the year and declared itself an independent nation. India was the first country to formally recognise the new-born state, heightening suspicion that it had a role in the development.

Bharat switches off the TV and turns to his mobile, now the most powerful technological tool in human history. Since the launch of the ePhone, laptops had gone the way of the Telex machine. The new mobile devices do everything except brush your teeth, and that day



His Nano is second from top in the vertical car lifts introduced by the Delhi government to counter the city's lack of parking space



... and opts for the helicopter commuter service to avoid the traffic jams en route to his office.

isn't that far off either. His wireless-enabled e-Phone combines his personal computer, office phone, fax, scanner, electronic organiser, camera, TV and also allows him to conduct online services like banking and paying utility bills. He can participate in video conferences, upload and download documents, e-mail reports, collaborate on projects, conduct research, schedule virtual meetings, scan documents and images, send or receive text, audio and video messages and watch the latest news on TV. Bharat is using it now to test out his company's latest device: the Meal Planner. The dietary deficiencies noted in his last health check prompt the e-Phone to devise his lunch menu, picking dishes with the necessary dosage of vitamins, minerals, carbs and proteins. No wonder laptops have become extinct.

Bharat is hooked to his workstation at E-Uphoria, the hugely successful company that markets wellness, the hot new growth industry. He can use the desk-treadmill while checking mails and conducting virtual conferences and inter-office meetings.

